

Earning Links

A backlink and authority plan for Ochorus — how a free library of public-domain classics earns the links and mentions that make Google crawl more of it, index more of it, and choose it as the home of each text.

Idea #1 of the top-ten SEO list. Grounded in the repo: about 185 English books and some 600 book editions across ten languages, 800+ sermon files, 100 author pages, quote pages, the scripture index, reading plans and the free PDF/EPUB pilot. No traffic or link numbers for Ochorus are assumed — the measurement plan on page 4 sets the baseline.

THE DIAGNOSIS

Why authority is now the bottleneck

Crawl budget follows authority

The technical work is done: prerendered pages, canonicals, `hreflang`, per-type and per-locale sitemaps, JSON-LD and IndexNow pings. What remains is how much attention Google chooses to spend. Its crawl demand scales with how important a site looks, and inbound links from sites it already trusts are the strongest outside signal of that.

The “Discovered – not indexed” pile

Search Console shows URLs Google knows about but has not yet fetched. That is the classic symptom of a site whose inventory (thousands of chapter, locale and scripture URLs) has outgrown its perceived importance. More sitemaps will not move it; more reasons to care will.

WHAT A GOOD LINK LOOKS LIKE FOR OCHORUS

BETTER	WEAKER
Deep: to <code>/books/humility-2/</code> , <code>/authors/andrew-murray/</code> , a quote or scripture page	The home page only
Topical: a church, seminary, ministry, Christian writer or library guide	Generic directories, unrelated blogs
Language-matched: a Swahili church site to <code>/sw/...</code> , a Brazilian blog to <code>/pt/...</code>	Every locale pointed at the English page
Editorial: placed because it helps the reader, in body text or a curated list	Footers, sidebars, profile fields, widgets
Lasting: a reading list, syllabus, resource page or Wikidata statement	A one-day social post

Natural anchors are fine (“read *Humility* free online”, “Ochorus”). Never ask for exact-match keyword anchors — that pattern is what spam systems look for.

Duplicate-canonical competition

The English texts also live on CCEL, Project Gutenberg, Wikisource, the Internet Archive and many small sites. When Google sees near-identical text it picks one URL to show. Links pointing to a *specific* Ochorus book page are one of the few levers that tilt that choice — alongside what only Ochorus has: the translations, the Modern English and young-reader editions, sourced quotes, and the scripture cross-index.

The upside is concentrated

A link to a book or author page passes value down through its chapters and across its locale siblings via internal links and `hreflang`. A few dozen good deep links do more than hundreds of directory listings to the home page.

IF YOU DO FIVE THINGS FIRST

- 1 Set the baseline this week.** Export the Search Console Links report and the per-sitemap indexing counts, so every later step can be judged (page 4).
- 2 Reclaim the easy ones.** Find existing mentions of Ochorus (and the old WordPress URLs) that carry no link or a broken one, and ask for a fix (channel 12).
- 3 Pitch library and seminary guides.** Ten librarians a week, each offered the two or three book pages that fit their guide (channel 1).
- 4 Build one linkable asset.** An “A–Z of Christian classics” or a printable reading-plan pack gives every pitch something better to point at (channel 9).
- 5 Start one language partnership.** A Swahili or Luganda church or ministry network in East Africa, where the team already has relationships (channel 4).

Effort tags on pages 2–3: **QUICK WIN** a few hours once · **WEEKLY HABIT** a standing slot · **PROJECT** something to build or a campaign to run.

WHAT ONLY OCHORUS CAN OFFER A LINKER

Ten languages

Swahili, Luganda, Amharic, Hindi, Arabic, Ukrainian, Spanish, Portuguese and French editions — the reason a regional church links here rather than to CCEL.

Readable editions

Modern English and young-reader (children / teens) editions of the same works, cross-linked as one edition family on each book page.

Free downloads

Print-ready PDF and EPUB for a growing set of books, with an About the Author page — what librarians and group leaders ask for.

Context pages

Author biographies, sourced quote pages, the scripture-by-chapter index, reading plans and articles: pages the plain-text archives do not have.

THE PLAYBOOK · PART ONE

Where the links will come from

Twelve channels, grouped by who is on the other end. Each says whom to approach, what to offer, and which Ochorus page to send them to. The common thread: offer something that helps *their* readers, and make the page you point at the best version of that text on the web.

LIBRARIES, SCHOOLS AND REFERENCE

1 Seminary, college and church library guides **WEEKLY HABIT**

Academic libraries keep subject guides (often on LibGuides) listing free primary sources; Bible colleges and church libraries keep reading lists. They link out readily when a resource is free, stable, ad-free and needs no account.

TARGET Theological and Bible-college librarians; subject guides on church history, spirituality, Puritans, revival, missions; church reading-room and discipleship lists.

OFFER / ASK One short email naming the guide and the two or three works that fit it, plus the free PDF/EPUB where it exists. Mention the translations for guides serving international students.

POINT AT Book pages (</books/the-reformed-pastor/>), </books/religious-affections/>), author pages, </biographies/era/...> hubs.

2 Open-access and free-ebook directories **WEEKLY HABIT**

Curated catalogues of free books are where many readers and librarians start. Listings are slow to earn but tend to last for years.

TARGET Open Library and Internet Archive records (where external links are accepted), free-ebook and public-domain lists, Christian e-book directories, digital-humanities project lists, open-educational-resource repositories.

OFFER / ASK Submit the downloadable editions individually, with clean metadata (title, author, year, language, licence). Only where the directory's rules invite it.

POINT AT Each book page that offers PDF/EPUB; the </books/> shelf for directory-level entries.

MINISTRIES, MISSIONS AND BIBLE SOCIETIES

3 Legacy organisations tied to specific authors **WEEKLY HABIT**

Many authors on Ochorus have a living institution, society, college, mission or museum that keeps their memory. Their "read his works" or "resources" pages are the most relevant links that exist.

TARGET Organisations descended from or devoted to authors such as Charles H. Spurgeon, Andrew Murray, Hudson Taylor, D. L. Moody, William and Catherine Booth, George Müller, Amy Carmichael, Mary Slessor and John Wesley; historical societies for the Puritans and the church fathers.

OFFER / ASK Offer Ochorus as a free reading home for the works they mention, especially in languages they cannot serve themselves. Ask for nothing more than a link where it helps their visitors.

POINT AT Author pages (</authors/hudson-taylor/>), the author's quote page, translated editions.

4 Mission organisations, Bible societies and churches in each language **PROJECT**

The translations are what no competitor has. The natural linkers are bodies that already serve readers in Swahili, Luganda, Amharic, Hindi, Arabic, Spanish, Portuguese, French and Ukrainian.

TARGET National Bible societies; mission agencies and theological colleges in East Africa, Latin America, India, francophone Africa and Ukraine; denominational networks; diaspora churches; Kampala-area churches the team knows.

OFFER / ASK A language-specific resource list they can publish ("ten free classics in Swahili"), a reading plan for small groups, printable PDFs for areas with poor connectivity. A local partner reviewing a translation is a natural reason for a credited link (review state stays admin-only).

POINT AT Locale pages: </sw/books/...>, </lg/authors/...>, </pt/plans/...>, and the African Voices authors (Crowther, Nsibambi, Kivengere, Luwum).

WRITERS, PODCASTERS AND NEWSLETTERS

5 Christian bloggers and newsletter writers **WEEKLY HABIT**

People who write about prayer, holiness, revival or church history quote these authors constantly and usually link to whatever free copy they find first.

TARGET Devotional and church-history bloggers, Substack and newsletter writers, pastors who publish sermon notes, homeschool curriculum writers.

OFFER / ASK When they quote an author, suggest the exact page with the passage. Offer resources they can embed or reuse: quote cards, a reading plan, the free PDF/EPUB.

POINT AT Quote pages (</quotes/e-m-bounds/>), chapter pages, </plans/humility-12-days/>.

6 Podcasts and video channels **WEEKLY HABIT**

Show notes are durable, crawlable pages, and hosts need free primary sources to send listeners to.

TARGET Church-history, theology and devotional podcasts; YouTube channels that read or discuss the classics.

OFFER / ASK Point to the free text for the work discussed in an episode; offer a guest conversation on a hook such as an anniversary (channel 11) or on making classics readable in African languages.

POINT AT The book page for the episode's work; the Modern English edition where one exists.

THE PLAYBOOK · PART TWO

Communities, assets and campaigns

COMMUNITY AND REFERENCE

7 Q&A sites and Christian communities **WEEKLY HABIT**

Forum links are mostly `nofollow`, but they send readers, get Ochorus noticed by writers who do link, and teach you which questions the library answers. Treat it as service, not distribution.

TARGET Reddit (r/Christianity, r/Reformed, r/TrueChristian), Quora, Stack Exchange Christianity and Biblical Hermeneutics. Read each community's self-promotion rules first; some forbid it outright.

OFFER / ASK A genuine, complete answer that stands without the link; cite the passage, then link it. Disclose that you run Ochorus. Most answers should contain no Ochorus link at all.

POINT AT The specific chapter or quote that answers the question — never the home page.

8 Wikipedia and Wikidata, carefully **QUICK WIN**

Done wrongly this burns trust fast. Done properly it is the single most-copied source of external links on the web.

TARGET Wikidata items for works that Ochorus hosts in full; Wikipedia articles only where an external link to the full text genuinely meets WP:EL and no equivalent link already exists.

OFFER / ASK On Wikidata, the "full work available at URL" property (P953) is a legitimate, factual statement for a hosted work. On Wikipedia, as the site's owner you have a conflict of interest: propose on the article's talk page and let other editors decide. Never add links in bulk.

POINT AT Book pages; translated editions on the matching-language Wikipedia, where those exist.

LINKABLE ASSETS TO BUILD

9 Pages people link to on their own **PROJECT**

Outreach works far better with something worth linking. Most of these reuse content Ochorus already has.

TARGET An "A-Z of Christian classics" — every work, author, era and language on one page. **Author quote collections** grown toward fifty per author. **Scripture-by-book index** ("which classics discuss Romans 8"). **Modern English and young-reader editions** — nothing else like them. **Print-ready PDFs** for groups and prisons.

OFFER / ASK **Embeddable verse and quote cards** that carry a credit link back to the source page. **Reading-plan packs** for Lent, Advent and small groups. Each asset should be the answer to a question a librarian, pastor or blogger already has.

POINT AT `/quotes/...`, `/scripture/romans/8/`, `/plans/...`, `/books/pilgrims-progress-children/`, a new A-Z page.

10 Translation and accessibility stories **PROJECT**

"Andrew Murray's *Humility*, free in ten languages including Luganda and Amharic" is a story a regional Christian outlet can run; "another free classics site" is not.

TARGET Christian news sites and magazines, regional and diaspora media, mission-agency blogs, ed-tech and digital-humanities writers.

OFFER / ASK A short, factual story with a named founder quote and one or two images; offer the locale links directly.

POINT AT The `/sw/`, `/lg/`, `/am/` versions of a flagship book; the African Voices authors.

CAMPAIGNS AND HOUSEKEEPING

11 Anniversary-led digital PR **PROJECT**

Dates give journalists and bloggers a reason to write this month. Plan pitches six to eight weeks ahead and verify every date before sending.

TARGET Annual hooks: Reformation Day (31 October; Luther and Calvin are on the site), Lent, Advent, birth and death anniversaries. Larger ones ahead: Andrew Murray's bicentenary (1828–2028), the 350th of *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678–2028), the East African Revival's roots around 1929.

OFFER / ASK A reading plan or collection timed to the date, a short essay from `/articles/`, quotes for social cards, and an offer of interviews.

POINT AT A themed plan, the author page, the anniversary article, and its translated twins.

12 Unlinked mentions and broken-link reclamation **QUICK WIN**

The cheapest links are ones already half-given: people who name Ochorus without linking, or link to dead URLs.

TARGET Search the web for "Ochorus" and old WordPress-era URLs; check Search Console for 404 targets with inbound links; find broken links to defunct free-classics sites on resource pages.

OFFER / ASK A two-line thank-you with the exact working URL. For dead third-party links, suggest the matching Ochorus page as a replacement.

POINT AT Whatever page the mention is about; add 301s for any old URL still drawing links.

THE RULE BEHIND EVERY CHANNEL

Point people at the **most specific useful page in their language**, and make sure that page deserves it: a clean title, the author linked, the downloads offered, the edition family visible. A link to a weak page wastes the outreach that earned it.

GUARD RAILS

What not to do

Google’s spam policies name these as link spam. Any one can undo the rest of this plan.

- ✗ **Buying or selling links**, including “sponsored” posts without `rel="sponsored"`.
- ✗ **Private blog networks** or sites built only to link to Ochorus.
- ✗ **Link exchanges at scale** (“link to us and we’ll link to you”).
- ✗ **Comment, forum and profile spam**; mass directory submissions.
- ✗ **AI-generated guest posts** placed for the link; scaled low-value content of any kind.
- ✗ **Keyword-rich anchors** requested from partners, or links hidden in widgets and footers.

Subject: The full text of the [author] passage you quoted
Hello [name], I enjoyed your piece on [topic]. The [author] passage you quoted is free to read in context here: [chapter URL], if a link would help your readers. Thanks for keeping these writers in circulation. — [name]

TEMPLATES

Outreach, short and plain

Subject: A free resource for your [guide name]
Hello [name], I found your [guide] and thought this might help your students. Ochorus is a free reader for public-domain Christian classics — no ads, no sign-up. [Work] by [author] is here: [deep URL], with a free PDF and EPUB. If it fits your list, I’d be glad. Either way, thank you for the guide. — [name], Ochorus

Subject: Free Swahili edition of [work]
Hello [name], your church serves Swahili readers, so I wanted you to know [work] is now free to read in Swahili: [/sw/ URL]. We would welcome your feedback on the translation, and you are welcome to share it.

MEASUREMENT

How to know it is working

MEASURE	WHERE	CADENCE	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Referring domains	Search Console > Links (top linking sites); Bing Webmaster Tools backlinks	Monthly	Steady growth in relevant domains, not raw link count
Top linked pages	Search Console > Links (top linked pages)	Monthly	Book and author pages climbing, not only 
Indexed vs submitted	Page indexing report filtered by each sitemap child	Monthly	Rising indexed share per locale and per type
Discovered – not indexed	Page indexing report, “Why pages aren’t indexed”	Monthly	The pile shrinking; crawl stats rising
Canonical wins	Spot-check 20 book titles in search vs CCEL / Gutenberg	Quarterly	Ochorus shown for more of the sample
Outreach log	A simple sheet: target, page pitched, date, reply, link live	Weekly	Reply and win rates by channel guide the next month

Links take months to show in indexing: judge on a quarter, and remember releases move the same numbers.

THE FIRST QUARTER

A 90-day plan for a founder-led team

MONTH	FOCUS	WEEKLY TARGETS
1 · Baseline and easy wins	Record the baseline. Reclaim unlinked mentions and old URLs. Build target lists for library guides, legacy organisations and one East African partner network. Add Wikidata P953 statements for hosted works where they fit.	5 library or legacy emails; 2 genuine community answers; 1 reclamation batch; partner shortlist done by week 4.
2 · One asset, steady outreach	Ship one linkable asset (A-Z of classics or a reading-plan pack). Pitch it to bloggers, newsletters and podcasts. First language partnership conversations in Swahili or Luganda.	10 outreach emails; 3 community answers; 1 directory submission batch; 1 partner call.
3 · Campaign and review	Run one anniversary or seasonal campaign (Advent plan, or an early pitch for a 2028 bicentenary). Open a second language (Portuguese or Spanish). Review the numbers; drop the weakest channel, double the best.	10 emails; 3 answers; 1 media pitch; month-end review against the baseline.

Roughly four to six hours a week. Expect a modest number of strong links in the first quarter; the compounding comes from the assets and relationships, not the volume of emails.

DECISIONS FOR THE FOUNDER

Who signs outreach — a named person earns far more replies than “the Ochorus team”. **Which asset first** — the A-Z page is cheapest; reading-plan packs suit churches best. **Which second language** — follow where a real partner relationship exists, not search volume alone. **Embeds** — whether quote cards may be hot-linked by other sites, and with what credit line. And a standing rule: **no paid placements**, however they are framed.